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How Small-State Allies Perceive Germany

Assessing Public–Elite Differences in Latvia

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Abstract Russia's full-scale attack against Ukraine in February 2022 shattered many longstanding pillars of the European security architecture. One of the most profound changes relates to Germany's approach to Russia and its role in securing NATO's eastern flank. In light of Moscow's aggression, Berlin pledged to strengthen its military footprint in the Baltic Sea region. In this process, has Germany met the expectations of its Baltic allies? In this paper, we seek to probe the views of Germany that go beyond the policy elite's level. Based on an original face-to-face omnibus survey in Latvia that included 1002 respondents, we assessed the public opinion of Germany. Contrary to the views expressed by political elites in the region, our representative survey attests that at the societal level, Germany is valued and appreciated as a security actor. Latvians, based on our survey, are rather favorable toward future German leadership as a security actor and express trust in its military support. Our findings reveal certain divisions between the political elites and the wider society that ask for explanations beyond the different compositions in terms of demographic and socioeconomic characteristics.

Keywords German security and defense policy · Public opinion · Foreign policy elite · Baltic Sea region · Latvia

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Wie kleine Staaten Deutschland wahrnehmen

Eine Analyse der Unterschiede zwischen Öffentlichkeit und Eliten in Lettland

Zusammenfassung Der umfassende Angriff Russlands auf die Ukraine im Februar 2022 erschütterte viele langjährige Säulen der europäischen Sicherheitsarchitektur. Eine der tiefgreifendsten Veränderungen betrifft Deutschlands Umgang mit Russland und seine Rolle bei der Sicherung der östlichen NATO-Flanke. Angesichts der Aggression Moskaus sagte Berlin zu, seine militärische Präsenz im Ostseeraum zu verstärken. Hat Deutschland in diesem Prozess die Erwartungen seiner baltischen Verbündeten erfüllt? In diesem Beitrag wollen wir die Ansichten über Deutschland untersuchen, die über die Ebene der politischen Eliten hinausgehen. Auf der Grundlage einer eigenen Face-to-Face-Omnibusumfrage in Lettland mit 1002 Befragten haben wir die öffentliche Meinung zu Deutschland erhoben. Im Gegensatz zu den von politischen Eliten in der Region geäußerten Ansichten zeigt unsere repräsentative Umfrage, dass Deutschland auf gesellschaftlicher Ebene als Sicherheitsakteur geschätzt und anerkannt wird. Letten stehen laut unserer Erhebung einer zukünftigen deutschen Führungsrolle als Sicherheitsakteur eher positiv gegenüber und bringen Vertrauen in seine militärische Unterstützung zum Ausdruck. Unsere Ergebnisse offenbaren bestimmte Unterschiede zwischen den politischen Eliten und der breiteren Gesellschaft, die nach Erklärungen suchen, die über unterschiedliche demografische und sozioökonomische Zusammensetzungen hinausgehen.

Schlüsselworte Deutsche Sicherheits- und Verteidigungspolitik · Öffentliche Meinung · Außenpolitische Elite · Ostseeraum · Lettland

1 Introduction

"Today, the trust in Germany is coming very close to zero," then-Latvian Defense Minister Artis Pabriks asserted in a public discussion in May 2022, shortly after the Russian invasion of Ukraine (Pabriks 2022). His sharp criticism of Berlin, questioning its reliability as a security ally, laid bare a clear strain in German–Baltic relations. While such remarks can be seen as particularly harsh, criticism of Germany's security role in the region has hardly been an exception. Since regaining independence in the 1990s, Baltic political elites have remained rather mistrustful of Germany's decision-making when it comes to geopolitical matters. Over the last decade, Germany and the Baltics have held starkly diverging viewpoints on numerous matters, from the role of military power and the utility of the Nord Stream 2 pipeline to Ukraine's membership in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) and the extent to which Russia constitutes a direct and acute military threat to the European security order. Consequently, criticism of Germany as a regional security actor has been a regular feature of the official political discourse of the Baltic states.

Against this background, it is well worth asking to what extent the Baltic publics, in our case study, Latvia, share the critical stance of their state representatives and foreign policy elites. By posing this question, we contribute to the larger body of research investigating the conformity between public and elite opinion. If political

elites in Latvia talk about Berlin's security role in a negative light, a considerable strand of political science literature would expect that this elite rhetoric will leave a visible imprint on public thinking. According to this view, ordinary citizens lean heavily on elites to make sense of the world beyond national borders. Political elites, the argument goes, assume the role of cue-givers to citizens who lack context-specific information and thus can exert substantial influence on ordinary people in foreign affairs (Baum and Potter 2019). Taking this top-down approach into account, Latvian society at large would be expected to fall in line with the expressed opinions of its security and political classes.

This expectation has to be considered in light of the issue salience at hand. The public is likely to rely on party cues in the case of policy issues that are not highly salient, whereas in the case of high-salience issues, people are less in need of shortcuts and more likely to process relevant policy information (Ciuk and Yost 2016). In light of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine and significant concerns about Latvia potentially being Moscow's next target, national security issues have gained heightened salience in Latvia. Coupled with extensive media coverage, this has provided the public with substantial exposure to information about the region's security developments, thus offering a strong basis for the public to form its own views. Based on the bottom-up approach, foreign policy decision-makers are expected to be responsive to public sentiments or face repercussions in the next elections. However, decision-makers with relevant expertise in an issue area have been shown to be less responsive than others to public opinion (Pereira and Öhberg 2024).

We aim to contribute to these debates by analyzing whether public opinion corresponds with the views of the most relevant subgroup of the political elite, the elite with relevant expertise and a direct role in foreign policy (Lupton and Webb 2022; Saunders 2022). To that end, we compare statements of government representatives and security experts with public opinion concerning the security role of Germany based on an original face-to-face omnibus survey in Latvia. We undertake this task without directly evaluating whether elites shape public opinion or if public opinion influences elites.

Existing scholarship has extensively mapped Germany's security ties with other major Western powers, such as the United States, France, and the United Kingdom, detailing their relational dynamics and historical legacies (Kaim 2004; Krotz and Schild 2013; Driedger 2020). This paper, however, departs from this conventional practice and instead scrutinizes Germany as an actor through the eyes of a small state in the Baltic Sea region, namely Latvia. Scholarly literature has typically treated small states as having narrower room to maneuver in international affairs (Jervis 1978). To overcome power asymmetries and to be noticed by greater powers, small states often strive to pursue an activist foreign policy (Park and Jakstaite-Confortola 2021).

At times, junior allies have managed to create a narrative of mistreatment by their larger alliance members to extract greater resources from them (Spindel 2023). As the work by Schimmelfennig (2001) demonstrates, Central and Eastern European countries, despite the lack of material bargaining power, managed to shame the European Union (EU) into changing its behavior. They did so through the deployment

of "rhetorical action." According to Schimmelfennig, these countries effectively invoked the community's membership values and norms to demonstrate that failure to admit them into the EU would amount to a significant blow to the ideational foundations of the European international community (Schimmelfennig 2001, p. 68). Indeed, small state actors, despite their relative weakness in material resources, are capable of finding innovative forms of leverage to influence their larger allies. This can be done by working through institutions, invoking norms, or bargaining their strategic locations (Long 2017; James 2021).

Focusing on Latvia as a small state security ally of Germany enables us to contribute to two strands of political science. By surveying Latvian society, we can evaluate the extent to which Germany's foreign and security policy, following the much discussed *Zeitenwende* moment, has met external expectations. While the literature on German foreign and security policy after Russia's February 2022–launched war is substantial and growing (Bunde 2022; Mader and Schoen 2023; Mello 2024), little analysis has been conducted through the lens of external expectations. The relevance of this study is further bolstered by the fact that Germany has increasingly turned to the Baltic Sea region as a place of great geopolitical significance. Over the past years, Germany has conducted regular military exercises in the region, assumed a Baltic air policing mission, and, most prominently, led the enhanced forward Battlegroup in Lithuania. Second, through its analysis of Latvia's foreign and security elites, the paper also offers insights into how officials of small states have attempted to maneuver rhetorically to extract greater concessions from a larger power like Germany. Overall, German–Latvian relations, with very few exceptions (Spruds and Vizgunova 2018; Vilpišauskas 2022), have received scant attention in the academic literature. Our study rectifies this knowledge gap.

The paper unfolds in the following steps: We first review the scholarly literature on public opinion on foreign and defense policy questions, with a particular focus on its link to the political elite. In particular, we underpin our research interest on whether public opinion overlaps or is distinct from the views of the elite. In the second section, we provide a qualitative assessment of how Germany as a security actor is talked about and perceived by the Latvian foreign policy elite. We use this section to provide relevant background information on governing and opposition political parties. In the third section, we report the results of a public opinion survey conducted in Latvia in December 2022, 9 months after the Russian full-scale invasion, a point in time when the general public was very much aware and knowledgeable about topics of security and defense policy related to this highly salient foreign policy crisis. Although at the very beginning of a crisis the public is at an information disadvantage compared to the political elite, this gap narrows, with information becoming increasingly available through media (Baum and Potter 2008). In the last section, we discuss the contrasting perspectives that emerge from the polling data and the statements by Latvian policymakers and conclude with some suggestions for future research in explaining this notable divide.

2 Security Alliances and Public–Elite Dynamics

Over many decades, political scientists have engaged in a heated debate concerning the extent to which the general public has a mind of its own when it comes to foreign affairs. Early scholarship, which came to be known as the Almond–Lippman consensus, posited that the general public lacked adequate information and knowledge about international events, as well as not being particularly interested in them (Almond 1950; Lippmann 1955). The views of ordinary citizens were depicted as overly volatile and lacking coherence. Early studies on public opinion, based on examining American society, depicted the general public as uninformed and capricious, a mass of people that often changed "its mood based on a superficial understanding of events" (Kreps 2010, p. 193). Hans Morgenthau, who associated with the realist school of thought, noted that public opinion preferences in the realm of foreign policy were "emotional rather than rational" (Morgenthau 1978, p. 558).

With time, more systematic scholarship, however, has rebutted this pessimistic assessment of the average citizen by demonstrating that, in the aggregate, there is a "rational public" that can have a more structured, coherent, and stable view of foreign affairs (Shapiro and Page 1988; Holsti 1992; Isernia et al. 2002). Particularly when it comes to questions on the use of military force abroad, citizens are capable of evaluating such high-stakes decisions in meaningful and rational ways (Herrmann et al. 1999). The generally "pretty prudent" public is more supportive of the use of force against aggression as compared to coercing regime change somewhere else (Jentleson 1992; Oneal et al. 1996).

Another notable line of contention in the literature has emerged regarding the ability of policy elites to shape the beliefs of the broader public. One strand of this scholarship contends that average citizens, lacking information, are reliant on elite cues to make their decisions about foreign events. In summarizing such a top-down theoretical approach, Kertzer and Zeitzoff (2017) note that most citizens are not well informed about foreign affairs and "adeptly swallow whatever their preferred elite cue-givers feed them" (p. 543). As Baum and Groeling (2009, p. 160) put it, the public relies on "information shortcuts, or heuristic cues, most notably the opinions of trusted political elites whom they consider credible." As such, this view posits that the formation of public opinion, first and foremost, is an elite-driven process in which the public takes cognitive cues from the political elite and the media. Especially in the domain of foreign policy, the public is at an information disadvantage. As observed by Saunders (2024), the general population traditionally relies on media sources for information, whereas "elites have access to information and can share it with each other or directly with the press" (p. 5). This information disadvantage, which is particularly pronounced at the initial stages of a foreign policy crisis, can make public perception more prone to the elite's framing and even open space for manipulation (Baum and Potter 2008). Furthermore, extensive elite influence is observed regarding public attitudes toward international alliances (Alley 2023).

Other studies, however, have countered this notion that elites can simply "spoon-feed" their citizens particular worldviews without any pushback. As a crisis progresses, more media reports and other information sources become available, the

gap between the political leadership and the public closes, and the public will be less susceptible to elite framing (Baum and Potter 2008). The process of information convergence, however, might be more difficult in a fragmented media landscape as characterized by social media (Baum and Potter 2019). According to Bullock (2011, p. 512), in instances when citizens are exposed to specific information, they can arrive at policy views that run counter to the views of their political or party elites. Kertzer and Zeitzoff (2017) concur with this assessment by describing elite cue-taking models in the literature as overly pessimistic. In their view, it is not a given that information can only "cascade from the top down" (p. 543). Work by Page and Bouton (2007) similarly speaks to the instances when the public finds itself in disagreement with policy elites, despite the latter's efforts to win over the citizens.

A bottom-up perspective goes beyond the mere notion that the public can resist manipulation by the elite and form its opinion independently. Instead, public opinion is expected to play a major role in shaping elite opinion, including in the realm of foreign policy. Democratic policymakers who want to be reelected have an interest in satisfying their winning coalition and responding to the preferences of the selectorate (Bueno de Mesquita and Down 2006). While voting preferences are often attributed to economic issues, security policy can matter a great deal. Recent survey experiments have revealed that members of parliament take public opinion into account when deciding on the use of force and partly express concern about repercussions if deciding counter to public opinion (Tomz et al. 2020; Chu and Recchia 2022). Even non-elected officials are not immune to public opinion, as a survey experiment with U.S. military advisors indicated. The military officials were less likely to recommend the use of force in light of public opposition (Lin-Greenberg 2021). Similarly, U.S. bureaucrats in the executive branch were also responsive to information on public opinion when asked about the support of economic sanctions against Russia (Peez and Bethke 2023).

However, public opinion does not influence all decision-makers alike. Those who already have a firm view are less likely to be impacted, whereas those who did not have a strong preexisting position or are undecided are more receptive to public opinion polls (Chu and Recchia, 2022). Experts with domain-specific knowledge are less responsive. They can be dogmatic and overconfident in their own beliefs and dismiss public opinion if it diverges (Pereira and Öhberg 2024).

While our study is unable to determine whether there is a top-down approach in public opinion formation or whether, as suggested by democracy theories, public opinion will influence political decision-makers in a bottom-up process, we will assess whether the political elite and the public share similar views on topics of foreign and defense policy. Previous studies reveal significant differences in public and elite preferences. For example, the study by Page and Barabas (2000) of several surveys showed that the U.S. public is generally more reluctant to deploy troops abroad and is more in favor of multilateral deployments than political leaders are.

Various explanations exist for these systematic differences in public and elite opinion, ranging from diverse preferences due to different composition of these groups in terms of age, gender, levels of education, and income to explanations that emphasize the elite's better access to relevant information. High-level elites in foreign policy could gain rich context-specific experience and thus have more

knowledge in this domain than the average citizen. This also distinguishes them from general elites and impacts their credibility (Lupton and Webb 2022; Saunders 2022). In a meta-study of experimental as well as observational data, Kertzer (2022) found that actor-level traits can explain many of the gaps, but foreign policy expertise also matters. When comparing the political elite to a sample of male respondents older than 40 years with a college degree and an income above the median, the gap is reduced by half.

Historically, citizens in Eastern Europe have demonstrated high levels of support for NATO, especially in countries with a stronger fear and history of Russian intervention (Kostadinova 2000). Support for NATO was consistently high across Europe between 2000 and 2019 (Mader et al. 2020). In particular, the Baltic states and Poland's elites and citizens have been known as "staunch supporters" of an increased NATO presence (Thompson et al. 2023). According to the Kiel Institute's data, since Russia's war in Ukraine, the three Baltic states, on a per capita basis, have been among the staunchest supporters of Kyiv, outpacing countries such as Germany and even the United States (Kiel Institute for the World Economy 2024).

In Eastern Europe, the United States has been perceived as the most valued ally, the one capable of deterring Russia. An often-repeated line among Baltic policy elites is that the presence of an American flag generates important strategic effects (Mälksoo 2024; Banka 2025). For this reason, retaining strong relations with Washington is often viewed as the number-one priority across the Baltic capitals.[1] Additionally, the Baltic and Scandinavian countries also support an integrated European defense and security structure, which is explained to a large extent by a rise in threat perception (Mader et al. 2024).

Our study adds to the body of alliance-related research by assessing elite and societal perceptions of Germany. When it comes to the analysis of Latvian public opinion, a few studies have already touched upon Germany as a security ally. However, such questions have usually been "packaged" within broader themes about perceptions of friendliest or most important strategic partners (Andžāns 2023; Krumm et al. 2023). In our analysis, we ask more targeted questions about Germany as an ally and the type of relations Latvian residents desire to see developed with it. Such an approach allows us to gain a richer understanding of how the public perceives Germany and the extent to which this aligns with the thinking of political elites.

3 Latvian Foreign Policy and Security Elites' View of Germany

Germany's relations with the three Baltic republics have been tightly anchored through common cultural heritage, commerce, and extensive people-to-people ties. While cooperation in these particular dimensions has been rather exemplary, in the realm of "hard security," Baltic–German views have fractured time and again. Despite relative geographic proximity, German and Baltic officials have held conflicting

[1] This notion is articulated in key strategic documents. For instance, Latvia's current defense concept, first adopted in 2020, bluntly notes, "The U.S. is Latvia's main strategic partner" (Latvia's Ministry of Defence 2020, p. 21).

visions about the development of the regional security architecture. For the three Baltic republics, Russia has been the primary security concern, often depicted in existential terms (Mälksoo 2006). Consequently, from the early 1990s, NATO was viewed as the sole vehicle through which sovereignty and security could be best ensured. This is where the first divisions started to emerge: Leading European actors, Germany included, were not enthusiastic about the 2004 NATO enlargement to the east. Behind closed doors, German foreign minister Hans-Dietrich Genscher had staked out his position—the alliance's move in the eastward direction was not in the country's best interest (Sarotte 2021). Likewise, leading historian Kristina Spohr Readman notes that although in the early 1990s Germany did support economic and political processes in the Baltics, it equally pursued what she terms a "Russia-first" policy (Spohr 2004, p. 162).

Throughout NATO enlargement debates, Baltic leadership regularly chastised German lawmakers for their unwillingness to expand the alliance further east. Declassified U.S. diplomatic cables attest that, at some point, Latvian policymakers had feared some kind of backroom deal being struck between Bonn and Moscow concerning the Baltic security arrangements. In 1996, during a conversation between the Latvian president and the United States ambassador to Latvia, the former did not hide his distress regarding Germany. He expressed fear of a scenario in which Helmut Kohl would try to reach a secret deal with Boris Yeltsin, which would rule out future membership for those states bordering Russia, such as the Baltic states. He even insisted that the United States publicly reaffirm NATO's open-door policy to "help rein in German proclivities to cut a deal at Baltic expense" (Napper 1996). Only in the early 2000s, as Russian relations with the West went through a reconciliatory phase, did the German government agree to sign off on NATO expansion to include the Baltics. Later, a long-serving Latvian diplomat acknowledged that the German government was one of the slowest in Europe to come around to the idea of Baltic NATO accession (Teikmanis 2020).

Even as formal allies, the Baltics and Germany have had notable disagreements concerning matters of national security. In the aftermath of the Russo–Georgian conflict in 2008, Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania pressured allied governments to develop specific military contingency plans. Berlin had moved to block the resolution because this would be too provocative toward Russia. Only after repeated insistence by Washington did Germany agree to drop objections vis-à-vis developing Baltic contingency plans (Herzog 2010). For a considerable time, the Nord Stream 2 energy pipeline represented another sore point of disagreement. The Baltic states continuously characterized this project as a misguided policy by Berlin and a tool for Moscow to gain geopolitical leverage. In their public utterances, Latvian foreign and security officials repeatedly called on Germany to drop this initiative (LSM 2017).

Public criticism of Germany has been further grounded in Berlin's shortfalls in military spending. For many years, Germany has failed to meet the previously agreed-upon NATO benchmark of 2% of gross domestic product. This has not gone unnoticed by regional neighbors, which have lamented, both in public and private, that German military contributions are not commensurate with its economic size and strength (Bunde 2022). As a consequence, Latvian officials have waved off the

notion that larger European nations are in a position to substitute for the traditional security provided by the United States. Concerning the discussion of the so-called European strategic autonomy, the Latvian leadership has written it off merely as "empty talk" (Pabriks 2020).

On balance, it is worth noting that Berlin did gain some political capital in 2016 when it assumed the lead framework nation status in Lithuania. As part of NATO's implemented enhanced forward presence initiative, Germany was the first European power to deploy its *Bundeswehr* forces to the region. This novel force buildup after the Russian annexation of Crimea in 2014, meant to deter Russia, was seen as a historic turning point in the deployment of forces in the Baltic region, as it marked the first time NATO forces had been stationed along its eastern flank. Regionally, this development was greeted with open arms. Germany's diplomatic engagement also intensified.

Between 2014 and 2016, the German foreign minister alone visited the Baltics six times, an unusually high number by historical standards. During one such gathering, he conveyed the notion that Berlin was "highly aware of the Baltic's concerns of a Ukraine-like fate" (Engelmann and Matlé 2018, p. 33). Other German politicians and leaders issued similar statements of assurance. In 2021, for instance, German President Frank-Walter Steinmeier publicly proclaimed that "anyone who threatens the Baltic states threatens the entire North Atlantic Alliance, and threatens Germany" (Steinmeier 2021). Equally, though, while Germany stepped up its security contributions in Europe's East, it simultaneously continued to conduct a Russia policy, with an emphasis on economic engagement, that was at odds with the preferences of the three Baltic republics.

In 2022, with Russian troops amassing around Ukraine, Baltic lawmakers once again expressed their discontent with the German government. After Berlin had decided to block the Estonian government's attempts to transfer Cold War–era howitzers to Ukraine, Baltic leadership reacted sharply and decried Germany's lack of willingness to take decisive steps (Milne 2022b). The then-Latvian foreign minister did not hide his disappointment in how German lawmakers had handled the initial crisis (Crisp 2022). Another senior Latvian politician added, "It is very concerning that a country that is a European superpower, Germany, is blocking NATO's decision to deliver military equipment and lethal arms to Ukraine, to make it capable of defending itself. That is why I am not so sure if the Baltic states would be attacked, what would the German position be" (Kalniete 2022).

Another notable point of tension has recurrently emerged about maintaining a political dialogue with Russia. Latvian political classes had grown uneasy about the wisdom of maintaining a regular dialogue with the Kremlin. "Dialogue has been tried. God knows, Chancellor Angela Merkel alone, I don't know how many times made efforts to speak with Putin. He can be quite charming, and you can have a nice dialogue with him if he's in the mood, but it doesn't lead to anything," the former president of Latvia, Vaira Vīķe-Freiberga, stated to describe her skepticism regarding this diplomatic approach (Walker 2019). After Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine on 24 February 2022, Baltic political elites strongly condemned French and German attempts to maintain some dialogue with the Kremlin (Milne 2022a). When German Chancellor Olaf Scholz insisted that even amidst the war, it was "absolutely

necessary" to talk directly to Vladimir Putin (Associated Press 2022), the Latvian political leadership responded rather harshly. "I don't see a point of speaking to someone who is committing genocide in a neighboring country," the then–Latvian prime minister countered (Karins 2022). The same sentiment was echoed by the Latvian foreign minister, who expressed the belief that diplomatic outreach to Russia would not yield any meaningful results (Hansler 2022).

In sum, the above captures numerous instances in which German and Baltic political elites have had diverging and, at times, even clashing views. While highly appreciative of Germany's economic leadership in Europe, Latvian policymakers have viewed Berlin's security role with a considerable dose of skepticism. As Rostoks points out (2023, p. 113), while Berlin has been "a reliable partner for Latvia in many ways," when it comes to security matters, the governing elites have exhibited deep distrust. Moreover, as the discussed material illustrates, Latvian senior leadership has not shied away from conveying these sentiments publicly.

The Latvian political establishment is for the most part rather united in its overall positioning on national security matters. Since the last parliamentary election in October 2022,[2] there has been a broad consensus among Latvia's political parties on the importance of NATO. All three current coalition parties—New Unity, Union of Greens and Farmers, and The Progressives—strongly endorse Latvia's NATO membership and the related allied troop presence in the country. The same applies to the two largest opposition parties, the National Alliance and the United List. Both underscore the importance of NATO to Latvia's security and insist on strengthening allied troop numbers in the country (Laganovskis 2022). Even the main Latvian populist party, Latvia First, broadly supports NATO. However, in attempts to gain some inroads with the ethnic Russian vote, it has tactically muted criticism of Russia's war in Ukraine (Diena 2024). One notable exception is the opposition party For Stability!, whose voter base predominantly comprises Russian speakers in the country. The party has carefully avoided direct condemnation of Russia's war in Ukraine and adopts a more skeptical stance toward both the EU and NATO (Lastovska 2024). Overall, however, pro-NATO and EU sentiments prevail across the Latvian political party spectrum.

4 Latvian Society's Views and Expectations

We assessed the public's opinion via a representative face-to-face survey at the respondents' homes within Latvia to gain insight into how the Latvian public perceives Germany's involvement in the Baltic Sea region. We submitted a set of questions on the perceptions and expectations for Germany's role as a security actor in the region to an omnibus survey conducted in the first half of December 2022 by SKDS Research Center, a leading Latvian polling agency. The survey utilized a meticulously designed multistage stratified random sampling technique to ensure that the findings represented the broader Latvian public. The stratification sign is the administrative-

[2] See the online appendix for a table listing the political parties, their vote share, party family, and party positions.

territorial unit. A total of 1002 randomly selected individuals were surveyed to gain insights into their views on Germany as a security actor in the region through several questions described below.

Given the nature of our analysis, surveying public perceptions, it is important to contextualize developments and headlines that dominated the international agenda at the time when the poll was conducted. After the February 2022 *Zeitenwende* speech and the announcement of a surplus budget of €100 billion for the military, the hurdles of constitutional change were overcome in the summer of 2022. Having faced severe allied criticism for not doing enough at the outset of the Russian full-scale invasion of Ukraine, by December 2022 Germany had already become one of the leading material supporters of Kyiv (Mello 2024). Between February and November 2022, Berlin allocated a total of €12.61 billion to support Ukraine, trailing only behind the United States in overall support (German Delegation to NATO 2023). Equally, though, during this time, the German government was also publicly pressured by Ukraine and NATO partners to supply modern tanks and other weaponry directly to Ukraine. At the time, the German chancellor remained reluctant (Kyranoudi et al. 2022). Moreover, it is worth mentioning that at the time, Germany was still on talking terms with Moscow. According to German Chancellor Olaf Scholz, his last direct phone call with Russian President Vladimir Putin occurred in December 2022 (Ahmatović 2024).

In sum, by the time of our polling, Germany, having pronounced its *Zeitenwende* moment, had become one of the leading financial backers of Ukraine while still facing pressure from allies to move forward with transferring various types of advanced weaponry. This was the international backdrop against which our polling took place. Public debates and media reports in 2022 intensively focused on matters of security and defense policies, and issues related to the Russian invasion of and support for Ukraine dominated the campaign ahead of the parliamentary elections in October 2022 (Auers 2023). Nine months after the Russian invasion of Ukraine, the information disadvantage of the public had narrowed. At the time of the polling, we could safely assume that the public was more knowledgeable about Germany's role in the European and NATO security architecture than during other times.

In our polling, we were primarily interested in understanding the public perception of Germany's potential role in shaping the security dynamics of the Baltic Sea region. Starting with a descriptive assessment of whether Latvians expected Germany to assume a leadership role in the future when it comes to issues of security in the region provides some first insights. As shown in Fig. 1, Latvians were generally more positive than negative toward Germany as a regional security actor. While most respondents were neutral and neither agreed nor disagreed with Germany assuming a leadership role, 32% of respondents agreed, and 10% even strongly agreed (compared to only 16% of respondents disagreeing or strongly disagreeing) with this statement. We also assessed confidence in Germany's reliability given that prominent Latvian politicians expressed concern that Germany could not be trusted as an alliance partner. Specifically, we asked whether Germany would provide military assistance in the case of an external attack. Most respondents (39%) agreed with the statement that Germany would assist in the event of an attack, and 12%

even strongly agreed; 33% remained neutral, and together, 16% disagreed or strongly disagreed with the statement that Germany would come to help in a case of need.

Viewed in isolation, 51% perhaps does not convey a strong vote of confidence in Germany. However, when contextualized with other international polls regarding NATO partners and their reliability, this result puts Germany in a rather favorable light. For instance, in a 2020 Pew poll, a median of 38% across 16 NATO member states' publics agreed that their country should defend an ally against a Russian attack (Pew 2020). The German public, in particular, has historically expressed deep hesitation on this issue (Pew 2015, 2017). Even the public of NATO leading power, the United States, is nearly evenly split (51%) on the question of whether it ought to defend the Baltic states if they come under external attack militarily (Smeltz et al. 2024). The fact that nearly half of the Latvian population is doubtful about Berlin's commitment to its Article 5 guarantees suggests that Germany has some work to do in terms of assuring its treaty allies. Still, considering the broader

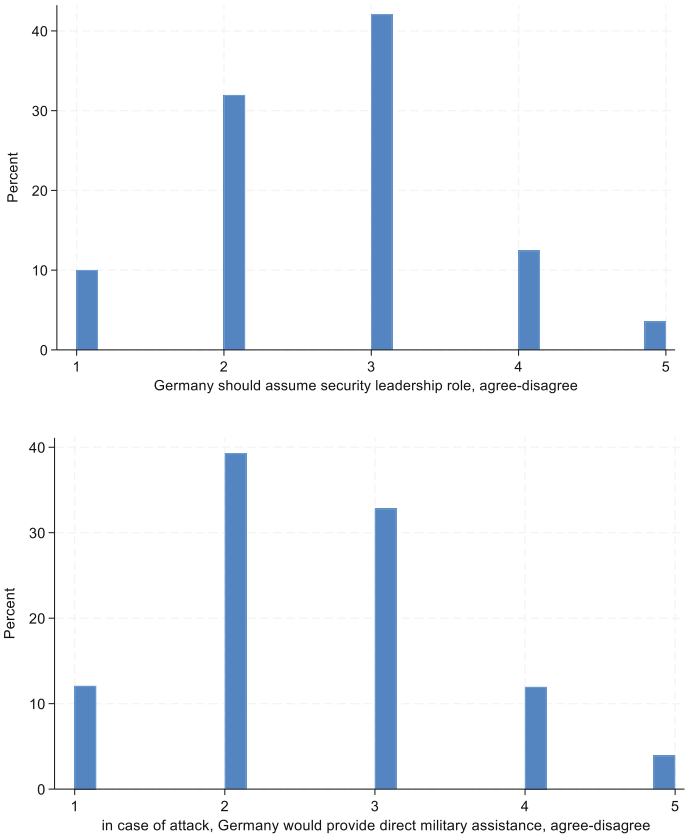

Fig. 1 Expectations of the German leadership role and trust in military support. Respondents were asked whether they agreed or disagreed with the following statements: "When it comes to future security issues in the Baltic Sea region, should Germany assume the leadership role?" and "In case Latvia comes under a military attack, would Germany provide direct military assistance?" The response category of "hard to tell" is not included in the presentation

alliance polling trends, the result can be interpreted as rather favorable. In any case, the public's view is more favorable and does not mirror the skepticism and distrust exhibited by Latvian political leaders.

The survey data from December 2022 so far suggests that the general public has a more positive view of Germany as an ally than one would think, given the statements of the Latvian political leadership. This generally positive assessment of Germany's security role was confirmed when we asked the respondents to rank Latvia's three most important security allies in NATO from the following options that we provided. Figure 2 reveals that Germany takes second place after the United States. This consensus in elite and public opinion in U.S. leadership is hardly surprising given that the United States is widely considered across the Baltics as the most important security ally (Jakštaitė 2019; Mälksoo 2024). While we do not know which other alliance partners the foreign policy elite would rank in the top three, Germany, to our surprise, was named by more survey respondents than the United Kingdom, which historically has played a prominent role in the Baltics, and France, which few respondents perceived as an important ally. The other Baltic states and Poland are close allies in terms of often sharing similar positions concerning defense policy, but, as our polling indicates, were not perceived as the most important security allies. These descriptive results generally underline the previous finding that the Latvian public is rather positively disposed toward Germany as a regional security actor.

In the following, we aim to get a better grasp on why public opinion diverges from government representatives' and security officials' public statements. Much of the public–elite gap in foreign policy opinion has been attributed to individual-level traits, such as a higher level of education and income in the elite compared to a representative sample of the population (Kertzer 2022; Saunders 2022). To get a better understanding of why the preferences deviate, we conducted a set of multivariate logit analyses accounting for various demographic and socioeconomic characteristics of the individual respondents. In particular, broadening the understanding of what constitutes the elite, we assume that the elite in society is the subgroup in our representative sample with a high level of education and/or high income. We

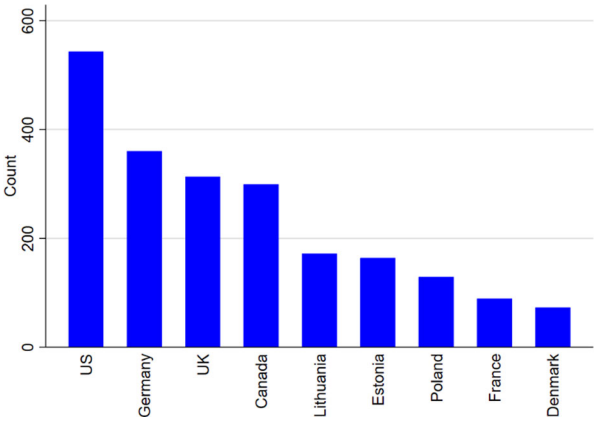

Fig. 2 The most important security allies in NATO. Respondents were asked to rank the three most important security allies in NATO out of the provided options. The categories "other" and "hard to tell" are not included in the presentation

analyzed whether respondents with higher education and higher income levels take a stance similar to the political elite in their assessment of Germany's future leadership role in security matters. To streamline the analysis, we transformed the five-point Likert scale into a dummy variable, which takes the value of 1 if respondents agree or strongly agree. This decision was made to capture an apparent dichotomy in public opinion, simplifying the analysis while preserving the essence of the respondents' attitudes. In tests of robustness, we also estimated ordered logit models (see online appendix).

In Table 1, we report the tests on whether the respondents were more likely to agree with the statement that Germany should assume a leadership role in security matters, accounting for the education and income levels of the respondents. Education is an ordinal variable for the highest school-leaving qualifications, namely basic education, general secondary education, vocational secondary education, and higher education. Income is the average monthly income per family member after taxes, including wages, salaries, grants, allowances, pensions, etc. To more specifically account for an elite within our sample, we also tested a dummy variable for respondents who held a degree in higher education and a dummy for the respondents who belonged to the wealthiest 10% of the representative sample, which corresponds to individuals with an average monthly income per household member above €850. Education and household income are moderately correlated, but to avoid multicollinearity, we entered them separately in the regression models. Please also note

Table 1 Agreement for German leadership, accounting for higher education and high income

	Agreement for German leadership			
Age	0.007	0.007	0.007	0.007
	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.005)	(0.005)
Gender	0.265	0.270	0.182	0.178
	(0.136)+	(0.137)*	(0.143)	(0.144)
Latvian speaker	0.623	0.619	0.536	0.524
	(0.143)**	(0.143)**	(0.150)**	(0.151)**
Education	–0.015	–	–	–
	(0.075)	–	–	–
University degree	–	0.061	–	–
	–	(0.154)	–	–
Household income	–	–	0.001	–
	–	–	(0.001)	–
Richest 10%	–	–	–	0.439
	–	–	–	(0.233)+
Constant	–1.418	–1.490	–1.450	–1.357
	(0.372)**	(0.253)**	(0.324)**	(0.270)**
F	5.60**	5.61**	3.92**	4.65**
N	1002	1002	875	875

Respondents were asked whether they agreed or disagreed with the following statement: "When it comes to future security issues in the Baltic Sea region, should Germany assume the leadership role?" Coefficient and standard error in parentheses

+$p<0.1$; *$p<0.05$; **$p<0.01$

that we had several respondents who did not provide information on their income, and thus our sample dropped to 875 respondents in these tests. We controlled for demographic factors such as age in number of years and dummy variables for gender and whether the respondent was a Latvian speaker. The sample consisted of 59% self-identified Latvian speakers, 31% Russian speakers, and 10% respondents of other ethnic backgrounds.

In the first two columns, the variables accounting for education and a degree of higher education are statistically insignificant, implying that the level of education does not add explanatory power to why respondents agreed regarding German leadership. The results for the level of income, on the other hand, are more indicative. Household income is positively related to agreement for German leadership (although not statistically significant), and the dummy variable for the richest in the population is even significant at the 10% level. This finding holds if a control for the number of household members is added.[3] Thus, individuals at higher income levels appear to be more positive in their opinion about Germany's role, which is not in accordance with the views of the political elite's statements. The control variables also reveal interesting results, with age being positively but not significantly related to agreement for future German leadership, men tending to be more likely to agree, and Latvian speakers also being significantly more likely to agree, a strong and robust finding.[4]

This finding could be driven by economic rather than security interests. German leadership has often been described as hesitant and associated with its economic strength (Blumenau 2022). Although we specifically asked about leadership in a security context, the opinion about Germany's role might still be influenced by the German economic presence in the region. As Vizgunova (2018, p. 100) points out, Germany is regarded by Latvia's business elites as "key for ensuring a stable, sustainable economic future for members of the eurozone." Germany also maintains close cultural and social ties to the region. Therefore, we also asked the survey participants which kind of relationship with Germany they found particularly important, allowing for multiple answers. The most common answer was that economic ties are among the most important relations between Latvia and Germany, with about 67% of respondents selecting this option, followed by security relations at 37%. Political, educational, and cultural relations were answered equally often (see online appendix).

As shown in Table 2, we investigated whether the level of education and high income of the respondents could help explain which type of relationship with Germany was particularly important to them. The higher the level of education, the more likely the respondent named security, but political and economic relations were also important. While not statistically significant at conventional levels, the richest were also positive toward security and political relations ($p<0.14$). Controls for age and gender were, for the most part, statistically not significant. Older people seemed

[3] When this is estimated with an ordered logit, we do not get substantially different results. None of the variables for income or education is statistically significant (see the online appendix).

[4] See also Pupcenoks et al. (2022) and Andžāns (2023).

Table 2 Type of relationship with Germany

	Security	Political	Economic	Cultural	Education
Age	–0.003	0.000	0.007	0.010	0.002
	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.005)*	(0.005)
Gender	0.013	–0.054	–0.067	0.007	–0.195
	(0.146)	(0.152)	(0.151)	(0.152)	(0.150)
Latvian speaker	0.888	0.347	0.432	0.226	–0.053
	(0.154)**	(0.159)*	(0.152)**	(0.158)	(0.153)
Education	0.238	0.159	0.171	0.095	0.048
	(0.083)**	(0.084)+	(0.085)*	(0.085)	(0.085)
Richest 10%	0.360	0.359	–0.226	0.318	0.316
	(0.240)	(0.242)	(0.256)	(0.251)	(0.247)
Constant	–1.878	–1.739	–0.325	–1.957	–1.049
	(0.420)**	(0.424)**	(0.394)	(0.431)**	(0.426)*
F	9.40**	2.62*	3.22**	1.97^{+}	0.82
N	875	875	875	875	875

Respondents were asked the following question: "What kind of relationship with Germany do you find particularly important for Latvia?" The options provided were (1) economic, (2) political, (3) security, (4) cultural, (5) education, (6) none of these. Respondents could select several options. Coefficient and standard error in parentheses
+$p<0.1$; *$p<0.05$; **$p<0.01$

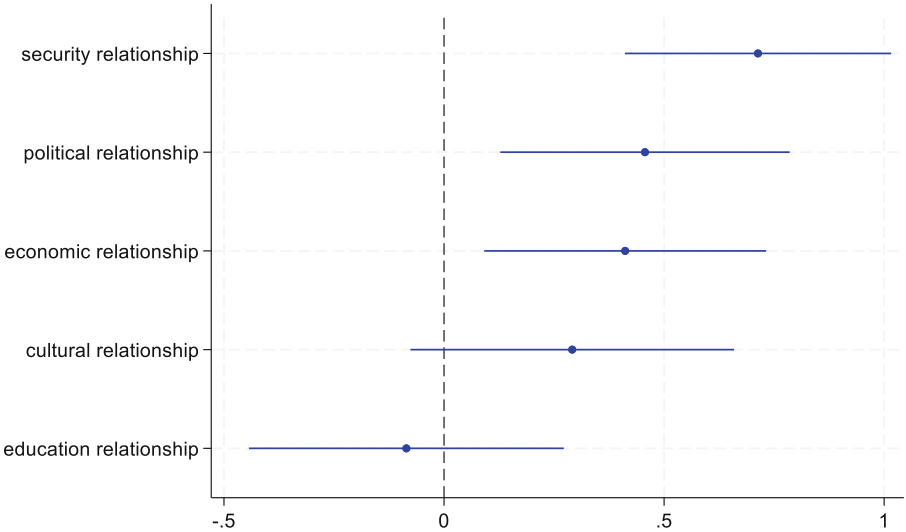

Fig. 3 Agreement with the German leadership role, accounting for the importance of the type of relationship. Coefficient plot with 95% confidence interval. Control variables omitted from the figure (see table in the appendix)

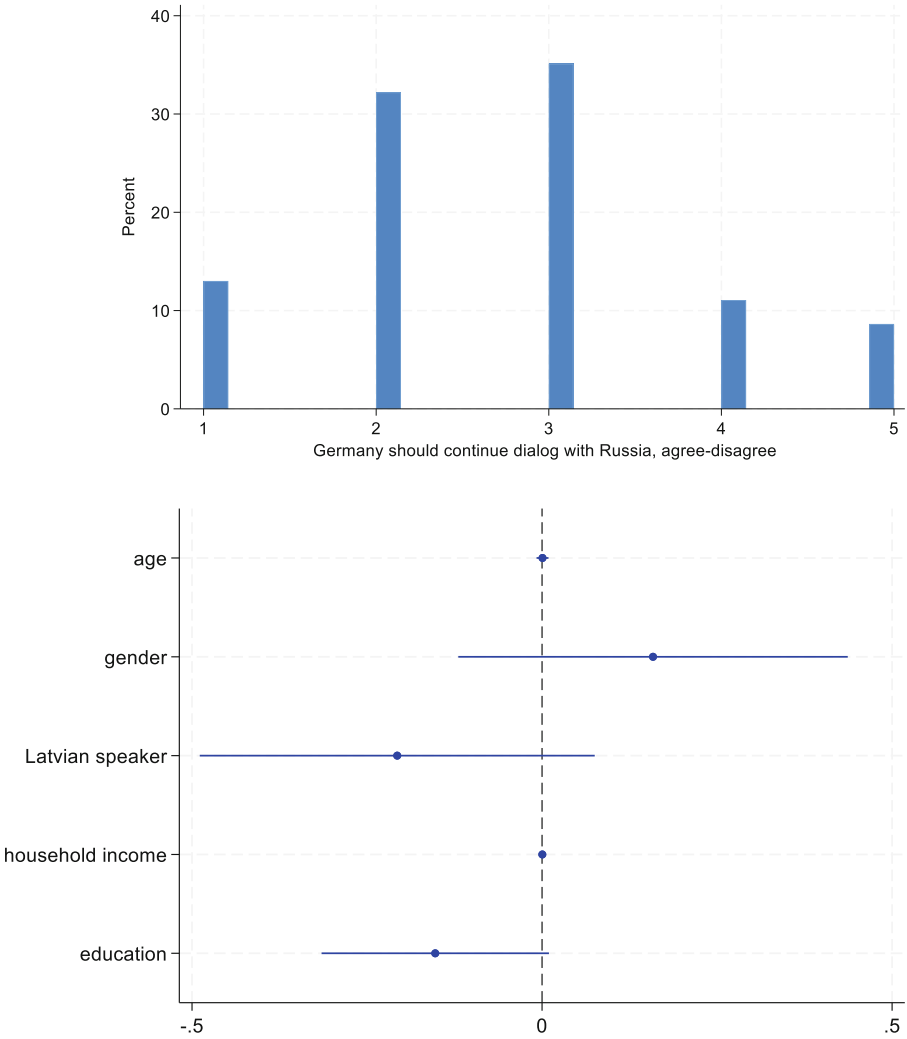

Fig. 4 Germany's political dialogue with Russia. Respondents were asked whether they agreed or disagreed with the following statement: "The German government should remain committed to a regular political dialogue with Russia." Coefficient plot with 95% confidence interval, based on Table A4

to value cultural relations more. Latvian speakers especially considered security relations, but also economic and political relations, as particularly essential.

We continued to evaluate how this assessment of different types of relationships could help us to explain whether the Latvian public trusts in German support and a leadership role. We expected that respondents who especially valued security relations would express more agreement with Germany's leadership role. At the same time, we believed that Latvians who considered economic relations to be important would also have a preference for strong German leadership in security matters. Figure 3 summarizes the results based on a model with all types of relationships

included. The control variables are omitted from the coefficient plot (see full results in the online appendix). As expected, respondents who emphasized the importance of a security relationship were very positive toward German leadership. However, the respondent's choice of the option of the economic and political relationship was also positively and significantly related to agreement with the statement that Germany should take up a leadership role in security matters in the future. Those answers that emphasize cultural and educational relations are statistically not significant.

Finally, we also assessed public opinion on a highly controversial topic between the German and Latvian political elites at the time, namely, whether Germany should maintain talks with Russia. When asked about whether Germany should remain committed to regular political dialogue with Russia, more respondents agreed than disagreed with this statement (Fig. 4). This is in contrast to the Latvian foreign policy elite's view as described above. When estimating a model including education and income, we found that household income did not provide much explanatory power, whereas education was negatively related to this statement (but only marginally significant at $p<0.12$). The more educated the respondent, the less likely they were to agree with maintaining dialogue. The coefficient plot in Fig. 4 indicates that Latvian speakers were also less likely to agree, although the coefficient is not significant at conventional levels ($p<0.16$). Gender and age are not statistically significant.

In sum, the results of the survey undertaken in December 2022 indicate that the general public (including the well-educated and economically well off) is rather favorable toward Germany assuming a leadership role in matters of security in the future. More respondents agreed than disagreed with a respective statement. They consider security, political, and economic relationships with Germany as particularly significant for Latvia. A similarly positive assessment was revealed when the respondents were asked about their trust that Germany would come to help in the event of an attack. Furthermore, the respondents ranked Germany as the most crucial European security partner, ahead of the United Kingdom and close neighbors Estonia and Lithuania. These findings overall draw a picture that is quite distinct from what we would conclude when concentrating on public statements by Latvian security and political elites. However, we found some agreement between the political elite and the more educated citizenry regarding a critical stance on Germany's continued commitment to dialogue with Russia, a result that needs to be considered with caution, given the level of statistical significance.

5 Discussion and Conclusion

Addressing the Latvian audience at the Riga security conference in October 2022, a representative of the German Bundestag, responding to a question about the lack of allied confidence in Berlin, insisted that Germany was doing a better job than its general reputation would suggest (Winkler 2022). Our polling of Latvian society demonstrates that ordinary citizens indeed view Germany in a better light than international news headlines and statements of Latvian leaders would make one think. Despite loud and recurrent criticism from Eastern European political and security

classes, public opinion in Latvia is rather favorably disposed toward Germany and its security role in the region.

The results of a face-to-face public opinion survey conducted in Latvia in December 2022 reveal that the majority of the general public considers Germany a reliable military alliance partner that would come to their aid in the event of an attack. The representative sample of the population is also more favorable than not toward Germany's assuming a more important leadership role in security matters in the Baltic Sea region in the future. Generally, a positive opinion is even stronger among the higher-income groups in society. While the foreign and defense policy elite is quite skeptical toward Germany as a dedicated and trustworthy security actor, the elite, in terms of the more educated citizens, consider security relations with Germany as particularly important. Thus, these analyses attest to a certain difference in opinion between the foreign policy elite and the mass public, including the high-income and highly educated segment of society. This suggests that it is less the different composition but rather the domain-specific knowledge and experiences distinguishing the political elite from the general elite that play an essential role (Saunders 2022).

How can we account for the seeming discrepancies between the Latvian public and the foreign and security elites? As a start, the information gap was narrowed over several months into this highly salient foreign policy crisis so that citizens have become more knowledgeable in forming their own views (Baum and Potter 2008). The expertise paradox hypothesis offers another account in that foreign policymakers are experts on national security and, as such, are likely to dismiss the preferences of the public if their opinions diverge (Pereira and Öhberg 2024).

Another possible explanation and avenue of future research for this disconnect may lie in the fact that the category of elites ought to be reassessed and potentially broadened to include not just the foreign policy and national security establishment. As Smetana and Onderco (2022, p. 7) note in their work on elite–public gaps, scholars should seek to carefully "disaggregate the elite category." This can include unelected officials (Lin-Greenberg 2021; Peez and Bethke 2023), and it may go beyond state officials and include, for instance, business and cultural elites. Likewise, Kertzer and Renshon (2022) draw attention to this conceptual challenge by submitting that there has been widespread disagreement about who shall count as a political elite.

In this context, it is well worth noting that, notwithstanding criticism of Germany's security role, Riga and Berlin maintain outstanding and deeply institutionalized links in business, culture, and education. Germany remains one of Latvia's key trading partners. In exports and imports, Germany ranks among Latvia's top three trading partners (European Union 2023). Around 1200 companies with German capital operate in Latvia (German Federal Foreign Office 2023). As noted by Bukovskis (2012), the attraction of German investments and business opportunities has been essential for the Latvian state. From this angle, Germany has been routinely talked about as an indispensable partner. This speaks to the fact that by broadening the notion of what constitutes an elite, we can observe a much more positive depiction of Germany as an actor.

The web of common German–Latvian ties is further extended by German governmental and nongovernmental organizations that boast a sizable presence in Riga and

have been active there since the early 1990s. Organizations such as the Friedrich-Ebert-Stiftung, the Konrad-Adenauer-Stiftung, and the Goethe-Institut Lettland are all heavily invested in Latvia's social scene, promoting German culture, business, and science as well as running various exchange opportunities. They have partnered with numerous Latvian intellectual centers, thus advancing academic debates on issues such as history and cooperation in the Baltic Sea region (Vizgunova 2018, p. 100).

Thus, these "other" elite pronouncements concerning Germany, which are palpably more positive, may overshadow critical utterances by Latvian political and security classes concerning Germany's security role. The narratives that are often part of international headlines and zoom in on Latvian leadership "slamming" and "rebuking" (Milne 2022a; Drozdiak 2023) Berlin for its seemingly inadequate security role are not the only elite cues that average Latvian citizens are exposed to. Put differently, a sole focus on security and political elites may overlook a different and more positive image of Germany cultivated and maintained by business, intellectual, and cultural elites in Latvia.

While the Latvian security and political elites' criticism of Germany appears to be born out of genuine dissatisfaction, one should also not rule out that harsh rhetoric can also be purposefully instrumentalized to draw as many benefits from allied relations as possible. Here, an illustrative case is provided by neighboring Lithuania, whose leaders appeared to have used public criticism of Germany as a bargaining tool. After securing a commitment from Berlin to deploy a permanent brigade, the Lithuanian prime minister indicated that a hardline approach had paid its dividends and justified Vilnius's tough language vis-à-vis Germany: "We have received some criticism that we have taken a very hard line, that maybe it's not nice and we should not do that [...] Clearly, it's not only possible, but it's also necessary to defend one's interests" (LRT 2023).

In this instance, the bargaining hand of these small states might also be strengthened by the fact that with the full-scale war in Ukraine, their suspicions about Russian revanchism have been confirmed. Whereas previous Baltic warnings about Russia were often disregarded, Moscow's launched military campaign in February 2022 validated the Baltic states' stance and amplified their voices in Europe. For instance, German Foreign Minister Annalena Baerbock admitted that Berlin had neglected to give sufficient attention to the repeated warnings about Russia coming from these allies (Jakučionis 2022). Recognizing that small states typically have less leverage to shape the outcomes, Baltic officials have tried to use this acquired moral high ground instrumentally to draw attention to their security needs.

Indeed, these arguments are also validated by academic scholarship, which demonstrates that "in bargaining and decision-making exercises, elites tend to behave differently than the public" (Smetana and Onderco 2022, p. 2). Even long-standing allies occasionally undertake the "naming and shaming" approach toward each other. While such a bargaining track is not necessarily consistently productive (Becker et al. 2023; Blankenship 2024), it is nonetheless a common feature of security alliances. This phenomenon may also be more pronounced in asymmetric allied relations. Lacking material leverage in interalliance bargaining situations, public shaming and harsh language, in line with Schimmelfennig's (2001) work,

may be one of the few tools available to small states to achieve their desired policy outcomes.

A crucial role in narrowing the information gap between the public and the elite is attributed to the media (Baum and Potter 2008). Future research needs to account not only for the public's access to different types of news reports but also for an important research gap: the elite's choice of communication outlets and whether they address an international or a domestic audience. Latvia's political leadership has strategically utilized the international press to criticize Germany, often targeting a foreign audience. As former Latvian Defense Minister Artis Pabriks acknowledged, Latvian elites are actively seeking channels and mediums in Germany to communicate their security concerns (Pabriks 2020). While Latvian leaders regularly communicate their security concerns internationally, the average citizen might not always be aware of these efforts. Overall, the media landscape in Latvia is defined by a strong presence and consumption of national media (Latvijas Fakti 2021). The strong reliance on local news, both in Latvian and Russian, means that much of the population is not consistently exposed to the narratives or pronouncements of Latvian security elites, which are often directed toward international audiences via English language mediums.

Since late 2022, numerous developments have taken place, suggesting a greater alignment of views at the political and security elites' level. With Germany's further active involvement in the Baltic Sea region security landscape, state officials in Latvia have begun to adjust their tone and rhetoric concerning Berlin. The government elites' rhetoric surrounding Germany appears to have shifted from a security laggard to an essential ally. Upon welcoming German Chancellor Scholz to Riga in May 2024, the Latvian prime minister depicted Germany as "an important friend, ally, and partner" in both economy and security (Siliņa 2024). While a more systematic analysis of Latvian political and security elites is in order, these are preliminary indications that a shift in sentiment concerning Germany as a geopolitical actor may also be afoot at the elite level.

Lastly, in terms of public sentiments, it may also be worthwhile to pay attention to the other side, namely German society. Previous polls revealed a deep-seated societal unwillingness in Germany to come to the military aid of NATO treaty allies in the event of a conflict with Russia. In 2020, a mere 34% of German respondents said that their country should fulfill its treaty obligations and use force to defend a NATO partner during a militarized crisis (Fagan and Poushter 2020). Early studies after the Russian full-scale war suggest that German society might be rethinking these assumptions. A major shift in public mood concerning collective defense obligations has transpired regarding military spending (Mader and Schoen 2023). There has also been a notable surge in public sentiment regarding the question of whether Germany should support the Baltic countries militarily (Graf et al. 2024). As Germany gears up to implement its permanent brigade in Lithuania, it will be worthwhile for researchers and analysts to pay close attention to Berlin's growing ties with Eastern European allies.

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